Theme B: Emerging Powers in a Changing Global Order

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Title: Ruling Long, Ruling Large: Leadership Longevity and Global Influence

Most leaders have abused their time and power by serving their own interests. However, three leaders are particularly distinguished by the way in which they used their power to transform the regional and global order. Traditional theories have focused on a country's economic and military might. They noted these as critical determinants in global influence; however, the role of leadership longevity remains inadequately explored. Political and economic capital has been accrued by leaders such as Paul Kagame of Rwanda, Lee Kuan Yew of Singapore, and Narendra Modi of India, who have ruled for long periods. These three leaders apply strategic diplomacy, financial leverage, and ideology to reconfigure the dynamics of the region as well as the positions of their countries in the global order.

The Singapore Model: Development Through Discipline

Lee Kuan Yew was Singapore's founding prime minister from 1959 to 1990. The administration of Lee is characterized by a powerful, centralized model of governance that consolidates power in the hands of the People's Action Party (PAP). They applied stringent anti-corruption policies and developed a highly technocratic civil service. All of which enabled Singapore to transform from a resource-poor island to one of the most effective bureaucracies and one of the busiest trans-shipment, aviation, and financial hubs on Earth. Singapore's real GDP per capita increased by around 500USD in 1965, post-Independence, to 14,500USD by 1991 and above 50,000USD in the 2010s. This model of transformation consisted of pro-business policies, considerable participation of multinational corporations, and mass public investments in education and infrastructure, including Changi Airport and the National University of Singapore.

Internationally, Lee managed to establish the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), which allowed the ASEAN countries to achieve more political independence by collaboration, as discussed by the signing of the Treaty of Amity and Cooperation. Lee's strategy built a reputation of stability, neutrality, and efficiency by hosting major summits and maintaining close ties with the US, China, and other neighboring nations. Singapore reinforced its status and is now frequently referenced by developing nations seeking rapid modernization.

In the meantime, the media press observes a juggle between economic success and political oppression in Singapore. Critics point to restrictions in political freedoms, strong restrictions in media and civil society, and the overpowering of the PAP. Thus, Lee Kuan Yew shows how powerful centralized governments are capable of

accelerating national development and globalization, yet raises questions about the sacrifice of high-speed modernization of economies versus political openness.

The Rwanda Model: Development Through Reconstruction

Paul Kagame was the commander of the Rwandan Patriotic Front (RPF), who had rudimentarily transformed Rwanda and halted the 1994 Genocide. Approximately between 500,000 and 1,000,000 Tutsi and moderate Hutu were killed in the Civil War before his election into the presidency in 2010. Rwanda has pursued ambitious reform agendas during its tenure of presidency. For instance, Rwanda's real GDP grew 8% annually between 2001 and 2015, meeting "Vision 2020" policy goals. This reduced the poverty rate from 42% to 10% between 1981 and 2015.

Rwanda positioned itself as a business-friendly and stable state in East Africa. The African Continental Free Trade Area agreement was signed and hosted in Kigali, the capital city of Rwanda, championing its aim to boost intra-continental trade. This method aligns with the policy "Vision 2050" goals of reaching upper-middle-income status by 2035. Due to the success of development in Rwanda, it is emerging as a regional hub for peace-building services and conferences.

Nevertheless, the decades-long tensions and mistrust created by the conflict between Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) are rooted in the 1994 Rwandan Genocide. Survivors fled into eastern DRC and formed armed groups such as the Democratic Forces for the Liberation of Rwanda (FDLR), which triggered the invasion in 1996. Besides, the natural resources are rich in the DRC, with cobalt and natural gas being commonly used in the energy sectors. Rwanda benefits economically through the March 23 (M23) group, which is a Rwandan-backed paramilitary organization that delivers around 120 tonnes of coltan to Rwanda every four weeks. Critics point out that Rwanda's invasion of the DRC is morally problematic. Human Rights Watch reports that over 1500 people were illegally deported from the occupied areas of eastern DRC to Rwanda. This invasion involves violating another country's sovereignty and enabling war crimes; therefore, the U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio hosted the foreign ministers of Rwanda and the DRC in Washington, D.C., to sign a U.S.-brokered agreement in June 2025. Rwanda promised to withdraw troops from eastern DRC and assist in the disarmament and neutralization of armed groups like the M23.

Furthermore, Kagame's long tenure has been underpinned by constitutional amendments passed in 2015 that permitted him to re-run in 2017 and potentially remain in power until 2034. This strengthened the continuation of the regime, but prompted concerns about the autocracy. His almost unanimous elections were mostly criticized as neither free nor fair because of the repression of speech and voters, and the disqualification or imprisonment of opponents as a way of undermining democracy. Kagame was characterized by Organizations as both a genocide hero and an authoritarian leader. His lengthy tenure generates a coexistence of predictability

and positive leverage of diplomacy alongside limited political freedoms and regional insecurity.

The India Model: Development Through Nationalism

Narendra Modi is the prime minister of India who secured three consecutive elections. His long-term leadership has centralized political messaging in India around Hindu nationalism and economic reforms. An example of this is the Goods and Services(GST) Tax 2.0 reform, which has dramatically cut the tax rate. It reduced the taxes imposed on essential goods from 12% to 5% and on other commodities from 28% to 8% with the intention of driving up consumption. India has also increased welfare schemes. India provided free food grains to more than 800 million citizens.

Internationally, Modi has taken India to the level of an Indo-Pacific linchpin by hosting Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) summits and defense agreements. The Quad introduced the Cancer Moonshot, Ports of the Future infrastructure, and AI & Biotech collaboration at the 2024 Wilmington summit. Furthermore, the corporation of the IBSA (India, Brazil, South Africa) and diplomatic visits to Ghana, Namibia, and Argentina in 2025 enhanced South-South cooperation on climate change and infrastructure. This illustrates how long-term elected tenure can deliver strategic coherence in global governance.

Nonetheless, Hindu nationalism alienated the minorities (the 200 million Muslims) in India. After Modi's 2019 reelection, the rights of Muslims have been explicitly ignored since new policies have constrained religious freedoms, encouraged violence, and aimed at disenfranchising Muslims. Moreover, Modi's government has overseen democratic backsliding. Modi's long tenure was partially secured through jailing opposition leaders, manipulating elections and courts, and censorship. The media faces pressure of being taken over, with journalists being arrested and charged for criticizing the government.

These long-serving leaders' personalized diplomacy builds globally recognizable political brands, aligning with the International Relationship Realism's focus on leader-centric power projection. Lee's technocratic efficiency model is the benchmark for developmental states in Asia. Kagame's post-genocide reconstruction elevated Rwanda's AU peacekeeping profile to project a security guarantor status in a region surrounded by regional volatility. Modi's "Voice of Global South" via Quad summits and Troika events positioned India as an Indo-Pacific bridge builder. Overall, these extended tenures generate a self-perpetuating political system that stabilizes governance but also erodes accountability.